

Fossil evidence for alleged apemen—Part 1: the genus *Homo*

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This overview analyzes the fossil evidence for the alleged apemen within the genus *Homo*. The differences in morphological features of the fossil species included in *Homo*, excluding the invalid taxon *Homo habilis*, are believed to represent, among other factors, genetic variation within the one human kind. *Homo habilis* is believed to represent a collection of assorted fossils that either were human (e.g. *Homo erectus*) or were australopithecine apes. If fossils such as those categorized as *Homo erectus* and Neandertals were all fully human, then the case for human evolution essentially collapses, as there is an unbridgeable morphological gap between the australopithecine apes and these humans.

In Western society, the educational system and media teach and promote that man is, at best, nothing more than a highly evolved ape, and as their trump card, parade a string of supposed apemen fossils as the knock-out punch to anyone daring to doubt this tale. Is there really convincing fossil evidence proving that man has descended from the apes, or is this just another example of one-sided indoctrination into scientism, a materialistic philosophy that demands natural explanations for all phenomena in the cosmos?¹ Put another way; is it possible that the scientists who promote human evolution are not objective in their interpretation of the fossil evidence?

Paleoanthropologist Milford Wolpoff writes: 'In my view, "objectivity" does not exist in science. Even in the act of gathering data, decisions about what data to record and what to ignore reflect the framework of the scientist.'² Evolutionists John Gribbin and Jeremy Cherfas acknowledge: '... we must admit that the history of palaeontology does not read as a shining example of the pursuit of truth, especially where it was the truth of man's origins that was at issue'.³ They later say: '... we do know that the popular image of the scientist as a dispassionate seeker after the truth could not be further from reality'.⁴ Lastly, consider the following comment by Roger Lewin, author of the book *Bones of Contention: Controversy in the Search for Human Origins*:

'It is, in fact, a common fantasy, promulgated mostly by the scientific profession itself, that in the search for objective truth, data dictate conclusions. If this were the case, then each scientist faced with the same data would necessarily reach the same conclusion. But as we've seen earlier and will see again and again, frequently this does not happen. Data are just as often molded to fit preferred conclusions. And the interesting question then becomes "What shapes the preference of an individual or group of researchers?" not "What is the truth?"'⁵

Scientists, both evolutionist and creationist, tend to interpret what they see in the world through their own peculiar lenses, which represent their framework, worldview or ideology. If the lenses have evolution written on them, then the data will usually be molded to fit that preferred framework. The author believes evolution to be false, and that only through a biblical worldview is our true origin properly understood. According to the Bible, God 'made of one blood all nations of men' (Acts 17:26). There is no room for any 'apemen' pre-dating humans because 'from the beginning of the creation God made them male and female' (Mark 10:6). Therefore, all the supposed apemen belong either to the genus *Homo*, and are descendants of Adam and Eve, or they belong to extinct apes. The article gives evolutionary ages for the purpose of putting the fossils in an evolutionary context, but in no way implies agreement with these age dates.

Homo habilis (incorporating *Homo rudolfensis*)

The cranial capacity of *Homo habilis* ranges from just under 500 cubic centimetres (cm³) to approximately 800 cm³.⁶ Taxonomic confusion is perhaps the best way to sum up the current status of *habilis*, as there is considerable debate as to whether the fossils attributed to *habilis* all belong to the same species. Some experts have split the species into two, creating a new species, *Homo rudolfensis*, dated from about 1.8 to 2.4 million years ago (Ma), while retaining *habilis* (dated from about 1.6 to 2.3 Ma), albeit with fewer specimens in the latter.⁷ To further muddle the picture, Wood and Collard have even suggested that the species *rudolfensis* (exemplified by cranium KNM-ER 1470) and *habilis* (exemplified by cranium KNM-ER 1813) be transferred from the genus *Homo* to *Australopithecus*,⁸ but this latter notion has not received wide support. That *habilis* consists of at least two species is not accepted unanimously, with some evolutionists arguing the variation among specimens of *habilis* can be explained by intraspecific variation.⁹

In discussing the multiple species controversy, Wolpoff commented that some scientists had used *habilis* 'as a garbage bag'.¹⁰ Tattersall and Schwartz have described 'the status of *H. habilis* as an all-embracing "wastebasket" species into which a whole heterogeneous variety of fossils could

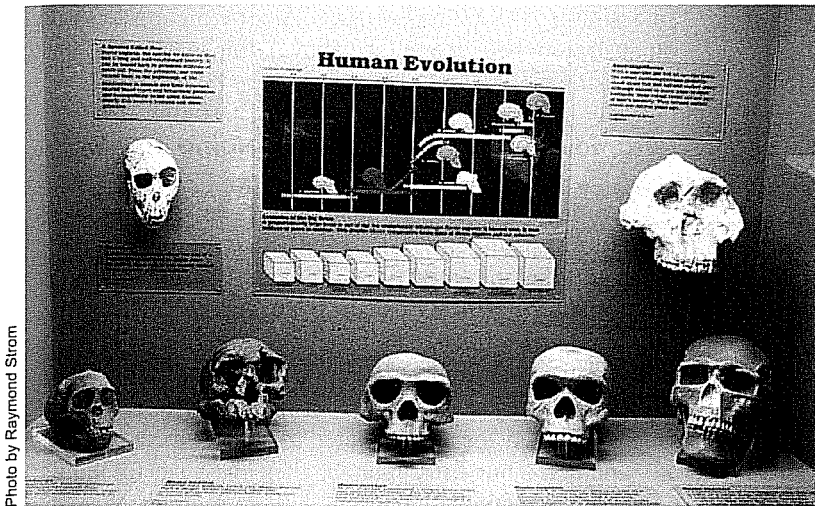


Photo by Raymond Strom

In Western society the idea that man is nothing more than a highly evolved ape is promoted throughout the educational system and media, and the trump card in this propaganda is to parade a string of supposed apemen fossils as a knock-out punch to anyone daring to doubt this tale.

be conveniently swept'.¹¹ *Homo habilis* is often presented as the evolutionary link between the australopithecines and *Homo erectus*, but even some evolutionists admit that this notion is too simple. According to Bernard Wood, 'Advances in techniques for absolute dating and reassessments of the fossils themselves have rendered untenable a simple unilineal model of human evolution, in which *Homo habilis* succeeded the australopithecines and then evolved via *H. erectus* into *H. sapiens*.'¹² From a creationist position, *habilis* is an invalid taxon, being instead a collection of assorted fossils that can either be classified as humans (e.g. as *erectus*) or as australopithecine apes. To illustrate this, some examples are given below.

According to Wolpoff, who labels *erectus* as early *Homo sapiens*, the cranium KNM-ER 1813 from Koobi Fora, Kenya 'is associated with a cranial base and frontofacial region that is so similar to early *H. sapiens* that authors such as T. White include ER 1813 in the same taxon (for him, this is *H. erectus*)'.¹³ Wolpoff describes KNM-ER 1813 as 'very similar to, really indistinguishable from, early *H. sapiens* in its teeth and frontofacial architecture (except for its narrow mid-face) but has a much smaller brain size'.¹⁴ If the evaluation of KNM-ER 1813 by White and Wolpoff is correct, then this cranium, with a cranial capacity of only about 509 cm³,¹⁵ may have belonged to a very small human.

The interpretation of fossil cranium KNM-ER 1470, from Koobi Fora, Kenya, which has a cranial capacity of about 752 cm³,¹⁵ has been problematic for both evolutionists and creationists. In 1999 creationist Bill Mehlert's analysis, which focused on the disputed reconstruction of the face of cranium 1470, led him to believe that the cranium 'looks increasingly like a larger-brained gracile australopithecine'.¹⁶ However, creationist Marvin Lubenow has long argued for

its human status, and, in his revised and updated book *Bones of Contention*, recently stated that 'comparisons suggest that skull 1470 is more modern than any of the *Homo erectus* fossils—even the Kow Swamp material, which is only about 10,000 years old'.¹⁷ Creationist Malcolm Bowden has also argued that KNM-ER 1470 is 'simply a small human skull'.¹⁸ Although there are variations between specimens KNM-ER 1470 and KNM-ER 1813, much of it can be explained, according to evolutionist Wolpoff, 'if we assume that the larger crania and faces with powerful postcanine dentitions (and their structural consequences) of specimens such as ER 1470 reflect body size differences'.¹⁹ Although a gorilla skull has been found with the same cranial capacity (752 cm³)²⁰ as that of KNM-ER 1470, the cranium of the latter is much more likely that of a human than an ape.

It is not the purpose here to give an exhaustive case-by-case review of the fossils that are categorized as *habilis* by evolutionists. However, an illustration of a *habilis* specimen that most likely belongs with the australopithecines (probably *africanus*) is Stw 53 from Sterkfontein, South Africa.²¹ Kuman and Clarke list several major morphological traits of Stw 53 that they believe warrant its inclusion in the genus *Australopithecus*, including teeth that are very large and a braincase that 'is frontally narrow and restricted'.²² Also, computed tomography (CT) scans of the bony labyrinth of the inner ear have shown that the semicircular canal dimensions in the crania of Stw 53 'relied less on bipedal behaviour than the australopithecines'.²³ This would seem to rule out human status for this specimen, the incompleteness of which makes an estimate of brain size difficult.²⁴ The labyrinthine morphology study led by Spoor did find that a specimen (SK 847) from Swartkrans, South Africa, associated with *habilis*, had canal dimensions that were 'modern-human like'.²³ As pointed out by the authors and other researchers,²⁵ SK 847 has also been linked to *erectus*, with Johanson comparing it to *erectus* specimen KNM-ER 3733.²⁶ Hence, *erectus* is the most likely status for SK 847, but the cranium is too incomplete to make a definite diagnosis. From the cranial base, Wolpoff has estimated a cranial capacity of less than 500 cm³ for SK 847,²⁷ but given that most of the cranial vault is missing, this estimate is at best a ball park figure.

Postcranially, the modern, human-looking femora KNM-ER 1472 and KNM-ER 1481 are often linked to *habilis* (or *rudolfensis*), particularly since they were found in the same Koobi Fora locality as cranium KNM-ER 1470, but as they all come from different sections of the strata, there is no direct association.²⁸ Analysis of The KNM-ER 1481 femur has identified it with *erectus*,²⁹ and hence indicates

it belonged to a human. However, some evolutionists still prefer to refer to it as *habilis*,³⁰ but this appears to be more in order to prevent the establishment of an *erectus* presence too early, as the femur is dated by evolutionists to about 2 Ma. Obviously, in this fictitious scenario, the further back in time *erectus* goes, the less time there is for *habilis* to evolve into it.

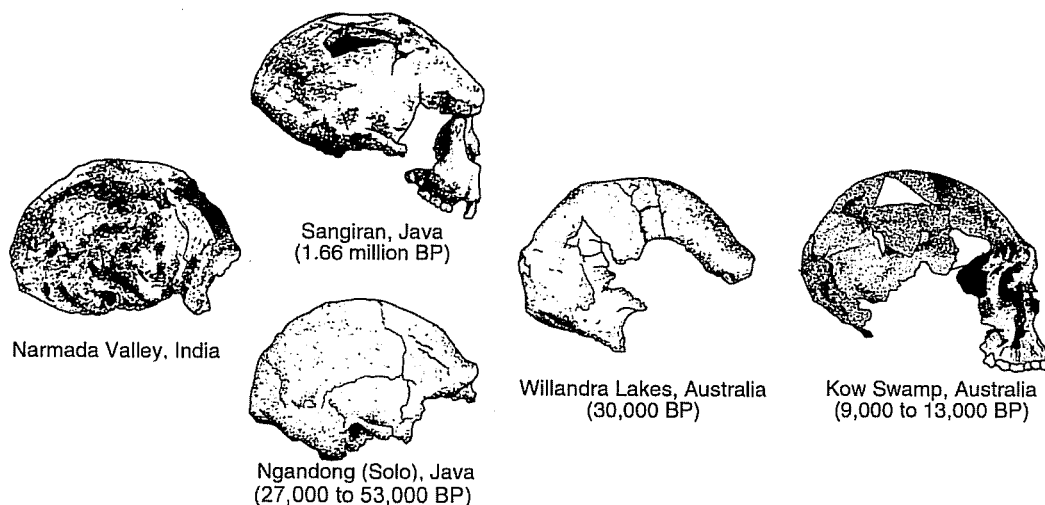
The most significant postcranial remains attributed to *habilis* belong to the partial skeleton OH 62 from Olduvai Gorge, Tanzania, which belonged to an individual that, at the time, was 'estimated to be as small as or smaller than that of any known fossil hominid'.³¹ Analyses of limb proportions have indicated a more ape-like humerofemoral index in OH 62 compared to the Lucy skeleton (*afarensis*), but this result depends on the limb-length estimates being correct.³² Most of the distal half of the OH 62 femur is missing, so its length can only be estimated by comparison to other femurs.³³ As illustrated recently by Haeusler and McHenry, using a different femur (OH 34) than the traditional Lucy (AL 288-1) femur that is often used in estimation yielded a humerofemoral index for specimen OH 62 within the modern-human range.³⁴ Hence, as the upper-to-lower limb proportions in OH 62 depend on which femur is used as a model comparison, this measure contributes very little to resolving its taxonomic status. However, the estimated brachial proportion, due to a relatively long forearm, exceeded that of modern humans, being more consistent with that of australopithecines and chimpanzees.³⁵ As pointed out by Lewin, it was the resemblance of the palate from the skull of OH 62 to that of Stw 53 that was influential

in assigning OH 62 to *habilis*.³⁶ As Stw 53 appears to be an australopithecine ape (see above), this may be the most likely status of OH 62 also.

Homo erectus (incorporating *Homo ergaster*)

Homo habilis is suggested as consisting of fossil specimens that can either be classified as extinct australopithecine apes or as humans, with some of the latter displaying *Homo erectus* characteristics. The fossils classified as *erectus* are believed by evolutionists to be the next evolved stage towards modern humans, with *habilis* the likely ancestor of *erectus* in this scenario. Using the rule of logic, if fossils attributed to *erectus* were not those of 'apemen', but fully human, then the case for human evolution essentially collapses, as there is an unbridgeable morphological gap between the australopithecine apes and *erectus* humans, with no missing links in between.

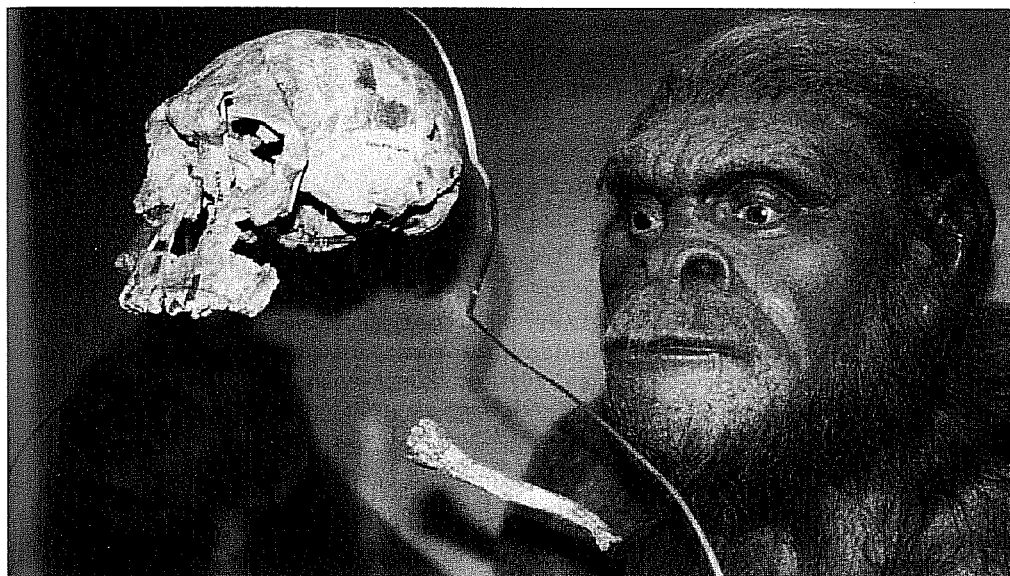
Fossil remains of *erectus* have been found in many parts of the world, dated by evolutionists from about 1.8 Ma to perhaps less than 100,000 years ago.³⁷ *Homo erectus* fossils from Java, Indonesia, have been dated to possibly as late as 27,000 years ago, which is quite recent in the evolutionary scheme of things.³⁸ Multiregional evolutionist Wolpoff refers to *erectus* as early *Homo sapiens* because 'no single definition has been found that distinguishes *H. sapiens* (defined traditionally as the descendant of *H. erectus*) from *H. erectus* in all regions where the fossils are found' and 'there is no distinct beginning for *H. sapiens* as long as *H. erectus* is recognized'.³⁹ Others adopt a multiple species



An assortment of fossil crania is illustrated above. The Sangiran and Ngandong specimens are classified as *Homo erectus*; the Willandra Lakes hominid (WLH-50) and Kow Swamp as modern humans; the Narmada cranium status is unclear because of the uncertainty concerning its 'evolutionary' age (usually given as somewhere between 0.15 to 0.6 Ma), but it has been classified as possibly *Homo heidelbergensis* or archaic *Homo sapiens*. Studies have shown a closer affinity of the modern human cranium WLH-50 to the Ngandong *erectus*, than compared to modern human late Pleistocene Africans and Levantines.⁷⁹ This questions the notion of classifying *Homo sapiens* and *Homo erectus* as separate species.

approach, which, in its simplest form, 'distinguishes early African *H. erectus* (i.e. fossils mostly from Koobi Fora and West Turkana) as *H. ergaster*, but leaves other African *H. erectus* (e.g. OH 9) and the Asian fossils within *H. erectus* (*sensu stricto*)'.⁴⁰ Here, *erectus* will be considered in the broad sense, including fossils from the restricted definitions of both *Homo erectus* and *Homo ergaster*.

At an average of about 973 cm³,⁴¹ the brain size of *erectus* is smaller than the average, of about



A display at the San Diego Museum of Man, shows a replica KNM-ER 1470 cranium shadowed by a couple of 'apemen' models.

1,350 cm³,⁴² for living humans. The cranial capacity range for *erectus* (727–1,251 cm³) listed by Rightmire⁴³ is in the lower end of the broadest definition of the modern-human range (700–2,200 cm³) given by Molnar.⁴⁴ However, Molnar gave no source for the lower limit (700 cm³),⁴⁵ and so the lowest brain size on record for a normal adult is possibly a Melanesian with a cranial capacity of 790 cm³.⁴⁶

The crania assigned to *erectus* by Rightmire included Ngandong series, Zhoukoudian series, OH 9, OH 12, Bouri, Trinil, Sangiran series, Dmanisi 2280, KNM-ER 3883, KNM-ER 3733, Buia, Gongwangling, Sale, Hexian, Ceprano and KNM-WT 15000.⁴³ The table of *erectus* cranial capacities by Rightmire did not include the 'older subadult or young adult' Dmanisi cranium D2282 (~650 cm³)⁴⁷ and the most recent Dmanisi cranium D2700 (~600 cm³),⁴⁸ the age of which is stated as lying between the juvenile KNM-WT 15000 and D2282.⁴⁹ Although still not adult, the cranial capacity of these two Dmanisi specimens, assigned to *erectus*, would not be expected to expand significantly more. The other Dmanisi cranium (D2280) has a measured cranial capacity of 775 cm³.⁴⁷ However, there is also a lower jaw (D2600), unearthed in 2000, that has been described as 'enormous' and 'far too large to fit comfortably with any of the crania yet discovered'.⁵⁰ This large variation in size has led to suggestions that more than one species is represented by the Dmanisi fossils (dated by evolutionists to 1.75 Ma), but as the fossils were found in the same stratigraphic layer, it is more likely that they are all members of the same population.⁵¹ Stone tools⁵² found at the Dmanisi site indicate a human presence, and the Dmanisi specimens most likely represent the makers of the tools. That there appears to be a large difference in cranium size within the Dmanisi human population, assuming that the enormous mandible D2600 belonged to a much larger cranium than

the others, is consistent with the enormous variation in cranium size that exists in extant humans. A similar, or perhaps larger, degree of size variation than the Dmanisi fossils appears to be present in the Klasies River Mouth human fossils from South Africa (dated from about 0.12 to .09 Ma), regarded by evolutionists as 'near modern', as indicated by variation in lower jaw sizes, with one mandible (KRM 16424) described by Klein as 'among the smallest adult human jaws ever recorded'.⁵³

Brain size and intelligence

Does the difference in size, *per se*, between the average modern-human brain and the average *erectus* brain support the evolutionary notion that the brain has evolved in size during the alleged period of hominid evolution? The answer is no! According to evolutionist Holloway:

'The range of variation of cranial capacity of modern *Homo sapiens* is about 1,000 c.c., with no correlation between capacity and behavior readily demonstrable. Such a figure represents almost the total amount of increase in capacity from the Australopithecine level to that of modern man.'⁵⁴

Physical anthropologist John Relethford acknowledges that 'Although their brain size was somewhat smaller than ours today, *Homo erectus* had an essentially human skeleton from the neck down, made sophisticated stone tools, and possibly used fire.'⁵⁵ The ability to make sophisticated stone tools indicates that a smaller brain size was no barrier to *erectus* possessing human intelligence. It should be remembered that Anatole France, who had a brain size of about 1,000 cm³, only fractionally above the *erectus* average, won the 1921 Nobel Prize for Literature.⁵⁶ Hence, why would evolution (if it could) bother developing a larger brain, at great cost, when it would provide no obvious extra benefit to that of a smaller brain? Evolution is supposedly all about adaptive value of new novelties (a minute few of which may confer some benefit) that are believed to be randomly generated by freakishly improbable genetic mutations. Hence, if a larger brain has no apparent adaptive value, then clearly it could not evolve even if evolution was possible. It has not been demonstrated how even 'beneficial' genetic changes can increase the functional information content of the genome, as these DNA changes generally

involve only sorting and loss of information.⁵⁷ Hence, the mechanism for 'upward' evolutionary change is a mysterious 'black box'. The brain is almost infinitely complex, and to believe that some unknown natural force has been driving it to ever-increasing size during the period of alleged human evolution, without even any plausible adaptive value, is to believe in zero probability. Something else must have happened to explain the incredible variation in brain size of humans, and this was intelligent design by a Creator. The following quote by Holloway illustrates the dilemma for the evolutionist:

'For another, there is some difficulty in suggesting that natural selection kept favoring larger brains if there is no connection made between the neural structures of the cortex and increasing behavioral adaptation. That is, the very units which comprise the gradual increase in cranial capacity over the span of the Pleistocene, cubic centimeters, cannot be demonstrably linked with real differences in behavior. The modern condition, where there is almost 1,000 c.c. variation without behavioral difference that can be analysed, warns that in attempting to explain the increase in cranial capacity during hominid evolution, some other parameter(s) must be used.'⁵⁸

This has not stopped a plethora of evolutionary 'just-so-stories' on how we supposedly evolved a large human brain, culminating with the ultimate absurdity that our 'enormous human brain has been created by the memes'.⁵⁹ However, some may question whether the smallest *erectus* specimens had brains capable of human intelligence. If the recent fossil finds classified as *Homo floresiensis* (more later) are a guide, then the answer has to be in the affirmative as, in the words of evolutionist Kate Wong, 'Would anyone have guessed that a creature with a skull the size of a grapefruit might have possessed cognitive abilities comparable to those of anatomically modern humans?'⁶⁰ According to *erectus* expert Philip Rightmire of Birmingham University: 'If *Homo floresiensis* was capable of producing sophisticated tools, we have to say that brain size doesn't add up to much.'⁶¹ It should be remembered, as stated by Holloway, that 'One c.c. of chimpanzee cortex is not equivalent to one c.c. of human cortex, nor is it likely that any equivalent measure can be found.'⁶² Hence, it appears that neural organization is far more important than brain size, *per se*. Also, as discussed above, there is no demonstrable correlation between cranial capacity and behaviour, including measures of intelligence, as indicated by the following statement by Clark:

'So far as it has been possible to apply appropriate tests, there is within such limits no marked correlation between the brain size and intelligence. To the paleoanthropologist this lack of correlation is particularly disconcerting for it means that he has no sure method of assessing the



Louis Leakey found the *Homo erectus* cranium OH 9 in 1960 at Olduvai Gorge, Tanzania. It is dated to 1.2 Ma and has a cranial capacity of 1067 cm³. It has huge brow-ridges. CT scans of the bony labyrinth of the inner ear of this specimen indicate a modern human morphology, reflecting human locomotion. The photo was taken at the San Diego Museum of Man.

mental capacity of extinct types of hominid simply by reference to cranial capacity.'⁶²

Locomotion and postcranial skeleton

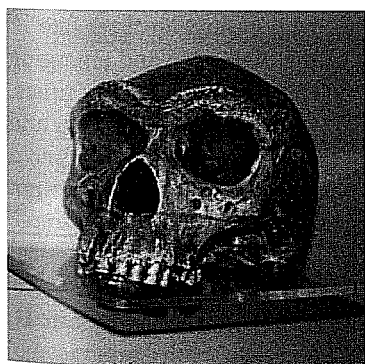
CT scans of the bony labyrinth of the inner ear, in the few *erectus* specimens examined (OH 9, Sangiran 2 and 4), have indicated a modern-human morphology, reflecting human locomotion.⁶³ As already mentioned, evolutionists acknowledge that the postcranial skeleton of *erectus* was essentially human.⁵⁵ The first *erectus* postcranial skeleton of any significance (KNM-ER 1808) was discovered in 1973, dated at 1.7 Ma, but because of a bone disease, hypervitaminosis A, it was useless in terms of giving a clear picture of normal *erectus* morphology.⁶⁴ The skeleton of the female KNM-ER 1808 was estimated to be 173 cm tall,⁶⁵ and at the time the *erectus* postcranial skeleton was represented more by KNM-ER 1808 than all previous *erectus* postcrania combined.⁶⁶

Most of the information about the postcranial anatomy of *erectus* comes from the later discovery, at west Lake Turkana, Kenya, in 1984, of the almost complete skeleton of the 1.68-metre-tall Nariokotome boy (KNM-WT 15000), dated at 1.6 Ma.⁶⁷ The skeleton is also known as the Turkana boy, and is classified as *Homo ergaster* by the 'splitters'. The skull morphology of the Nariokotome boy was *erectus*-like, but Wolpoff describes the postcranium of this individual as 'mostly modern'.⁶⁸ The limb proportions of KNM-WT 15000, specifically the humerofemoral and brachial index, resembled modern humans.⁶⁹ According to Lewin the information gathered from the Nariokotome boy skeleton indicates that the *erectus* postcranium 'is similar to that of modern humans, but more robust and heavily muscled', which 'implies routine heavy physical exertion'.⁷⁰ The cranial capacity of the boy, estimated to be 11 years old, measured about 880 cm³ at the time of his death, and an estimate of adult brain size is 909 cm³.⁷¹ As pointed out by Mehlert, there is no way to establish adult height size with certainty,⁷² but 185 cm is one estimate given for KNM-WT 15000.⁶⁵

To have such a tall *erectus* individual with a modern postcranium appear at such an early stage in the alleged evolutionary history of *erectus* is a problem for evolutionists. If evolution was true, then a more intermediate postcranial skeleton would be expected, one reflecting more of a mid-way stage between the australopithecines and modern humans, not one already at the modern human stage. Hence, there is a huge morphological gap between *erectus* and the australopithecines; the *habilis* taxon, as discussed earlier, is regarded as invalid. In what seems an almost desperate effort to dehumanize the Nariokotome boy, some evolutionists emphasize that the vertebral canal in this individual was smaller than in modern humans.⁷³ As such, they argue that his nervous system was not developed enough to carry out the entire fine breathing manoeuvres required for a fully human discourse, and conclude that at the time the boy lived 'Language, as we understand the term, had probably not yet fully evolved.'⁷⁴ However, the revelation that the KNM-WT 15000 axial skeleton had significant abnormalities, suggesting that there was some form of abnormal development in the axial skeleton of the Nariokotome boy, nullifies any such argument and it can explain the narrowness of the vertebral canal.⁷⁵ This verdict, however, is still not accepted by some evolutionists.⁷⁶

Skull features

Skulls classified as *erectus* are considered by evolutionists to exhibit key characteristics that differentiate them from modern humans. Key characteristics include: prominent browridges; insignificant chin; large mandible; forwardly projecting jaws; a flat, receding forehead; a long and low-vaulted cranium; occipital torus; relatively large teeth; relatively large facial skeleton; and a thick-walled braincase.⁷⁷ A major problem for evolutionists is that many (if not all) of the above-mentioned features, which supposedly differentiate *erectus* from modern humans,



The Broken Hill cranium from Kabwe, Zambia is classified by most evolutionists as belonging to *Homo heidelbergensis*. The photo was taken at the San Diego Museum of Man.

also occur in modern humans. This is illustrated in recent native Australians by the prominent browridges of cranium 3596 from Euston,⁷⁸ and the closer affinity of the modern human cranium from Australia, WLH-50, with the Ngandong *erectus*, compared to modern human late Pleistocene Africans and Levantines.⁷⁹ According to Shreeve, 'While some of

the early modern humans from Australia look much like people today, others bear all the markings of a more robust kind of human, with thick skull bones, swollen browridges, and huge teeth, even bigger than those of *Homo erectus* in some specimens.'⁸⁰

Examples of other typical *erectus*-type features in modern humans, such as flattish receding forehead and insignificant chin development, can be seen in a photograph of a living native Australian, published in the late Victorian age, when there was appalling racism within anthropology.⁸¹ Native Australians are as human and 'modern' as anyone else, and so the above *erectus*-type features cannot be considered 'primitive'.

Stringer and Gamble, advocates of the Out of Africa theory of modern human origins, referred to the presence of the *erectus*-type features in Australian Aborigines as perhaps 'apparent evolutionary reversals',⁸² triggering a heated response from a group stating 'such statements and their implications are unfortunate'.⁸³ Controversy aside, the statement does illustrate the chameleon-like nature of evolution theory, which appears plastic enough to accommodate almost any scenario. Clearly, there is no valid basis for rejecting *erectus* fossils as being fully human because of skull features that some evolutionists regard as being 'primitive' characters. Creationists are not the only ones protesting about the narrow definition of our species. In regards to the Out of Africa theory of modern human origins, evolutionists from the multiregional school of thought have expressed the following concern about defining the species *Homo sapiens* too restrictively:

'We believe that an unfortunate aspect of the debate are [*sic*] definitions of *Homo sapiens* used by some "Eve" theorists. They have been found to exclude many Pleistocene and more recent Aboriginal Australians from our species (Wolpoff, 1986; P. Brown, 1990). Further examination of these individuals and collections of recent Aboriginal skeletal remains leads us to estimate that these definitions of modern *Homo sapiens* exclude anywhere between 40 000 and 60 000 living Aboriginal Australians. We feel that there is great danger in this. It is the duty of specialists to make sure that they include all living people in any definition of our species. If we do define humans as minimally including all living people, many of the fossils that the "Eve" theorists claim leave no descendants, including Neanderthals, fall into *Homo sapiens*.'⁸⁴

For the purpose of analysis, *erectus* has been considered as a separate group, but is it really that different from other fossil humans? For example, are fossil specimens allocated to *erectus* just because of their skull morphology, or is there a trend of categorizing specimens with smaller cranial capacities as *erectus*, and larger specimens to other

Photo by David Green



The Neanderthal Gibraltar 1 cranium was found in Forbes' Quarry, Gibraltar prior to 1848, and is dated somewhere between 45,000 and 70,000 years ago. It is said to be the first adult Neanderthal cranium discovered, but was not recognized as such until after the discovery of the original Neanderthal fossils in the Feldhofer cave, Germany in 1856.

taxa, such as *Homo heidelbergensis* and Neanderthals? As the discussion moves on to the next group of fossil humans, the following comment from evolutionist Harry Shapiro is very revealing:

'But when one examines a classic Neanderthal skull, of which there are now a large number, one cannot escape the conviction that its fundamental anatomical formation is an enlarged and developed version of the *Homo erectus* skull. As in *Homo erectus*, it has the bun-shaped protrusion in the occiput, the heavy brow ridge, the relatively flattened crown that from the rear presents a profile like a gambrel roof. Its greatest breadth is low, just above the ears, and the absence of a jutting chin is typical.'⁸⁵

***Homo heidelbergensis* (archaic *Homo sapiens*)**

Homo heidelbergensis is a category invented to fill the alleged taxonomic vacuum between the Neanderthals and *erectus*. Previously, these fossils were labelled as archaic *Homo sapiens*.⁸⁶ Evolutionist Shreeve has referred to the taxon as 'more like a bushel basket into which you throw everything that is neither clearly *erectus*, nor obviously modern *Homo sapiens*'.⁸⁷ The *heidelbergensis* braincases are described as being 'more robustly built' than those of modern humans, and to 'have some, but not all, of the features of *H. erectus* crania, but lack the derived features of Neanderthal crania'.⁸⁸ The validity of having separate species classifications for *erectus* and *heidelbergensis* is questionable when, for example, the *erectus* Ngandong

series crania⁴³ have also been classified as archaic *Homo sapiens* (i.e. *heidelbergensis*),⁸⁹ and some evolutionists even advocate including the Ngandong fossils within *Homo sapiens*.⁹⁰ With crania displaying such interchangeability up and down the ranks of the genus *Homo*, evolutionists can hardly complain about creationists lumping the above species together. The cranial capacity range of *heidelbergensis* is between 1,100 and 1,390 cm³ (mean of about 1,206 cm³), with age dates varying between 200,000 and 700,000 years ago.⁹¹ The cast of specimens assigned to *heidelbergensis* includes Dali, Broken Hill, Bodo, Arago, Jinniushan, Ndutu, Petralona, Steinheim and Sima de los Huesos 4 and 5.⁹² The arguments above for assigning human status to *erectus* apply equally to *heidelbergensis*, particularly as evolutionists regard them as more 'modern' than *erectus*.

Homo antecessor

The tendency to split the genus *Homo* into more and more species is revealed by naming the fragmentary Gran Dolina remains from Spain, which included a juvenile partial face (ATD6-69) that had a 'fully modern facial topography',⁹³ as a new species, *Homo antecessor*. Surely room could have been found in the *heidelbergensis* 'bushel basket' to include the Grand Dolina remains. One suspects, with an evolutionary age (about 0.78 Ma) of the remains that was older than any member of *heidelbergensis* from Europe, the temptation to give these 'oldest known Europeans' a new name was just too much at the time, particularly as *antecessor* then 'claims a key spot on the human family tree'.⁹⁴

***Homo neanderthalensis* (Neanderthal)**

Neanderthals are believed by evolutionists to have been confined to Europe, western Asia and the Middle East between about 30,000 and 150,000 years ago, and are regarded by most evolutionists 'as a side branch of the human evolutionary tree, with extinction their fate'.⁹⁵ The relatively long history of the discovery and emerging knowledge of the Neanderthals has been told many times, albeit mostly from an evolutionary point of view, and will not be revisited here.⁹⁶ The Neanderthals had quite a culture inventory, and buried their dead.⁹⁷ To anyone not blinded by evolutionary bias, this in itself should be ample evidence that the Neanderthals were fully human. Classical Neanderthal specimens include Neanderthal, La Chapelle-aux-Saints, La Ferrassie I, Spy I, Le Moustier, Saccopastore II, Shanidar 1 and 5, Tabun and La Quina, while 'progressive' specimens include Spy II, Saccopastore I, Monte Circeo, the Krapina remains, Shanidar 2 and some of the Skuhl and Qafzeh specimens.⁹⁸ The Neanderthals labelled 'classical' are considered by some evolutionists to be the more 'primitive'.⁹⁹

The mean Neanderthal brain size of about 1,485 cm³

(range: 1,245–1,740 cm³)¹⁰⁰ is at the very least on par with modern humans, if not slightly larger. Apart from a large cranial capacity, Lubenow lists the following distinct Neandertal morphology:

‘(2) skull shape low, broad, and elongated; (3) rear of the skull rather pointed, with a bun; (4) large, heavy browridges; (5) low forehead; (6) large, long faces with the center of the face jutting forward; (7) weak, rounded chin; and (8) postcranial skeleton rugged with bones very thick.’¹⁰¹

Other adult Neandertal features include a retromolar space, broad nasal opening and large dentition.¹⁰² While evolutionists regard Neandertal as a separate species, a creationist view is that ‘*erectus* is just a smaller version of Neandertal and the most unique aspect of both is their skull shape’.¹⁰³ There are also non-evolutionary explanations for some of the Neandertal features, such as the stress of biomechanical forces influencing skull morphology.¹⁰⁴ Additionally, in his book *Buried Alive*, Jack Cuozzo demonstrates disturbing instances of faulty reconstructions of Neandertal specimens. In one example he illustrates how the Le Moustier specimen has been assembled to make the jaw appear more ape-like than it was,¹⁰⁵ and in another, Cuozzo presents evidence that the chin of La Quina 5 was cut off to make it appear more ape-like.¹⁰⁶

As mentioned previously, many of the features supposedly differentiating *erectus* and Neandertal from modern humans also occur in some modern humans. For this reason the proponents of the multiregional view of human evolution, in contrast to those of the Out of Africa view, believe that *Homo erectus*, archaic *Homo sapiens* (*heidelbergensis*) and Neandertals ‘should be reclassified into a single species, *Homo sapiens*, that is subdivided only into races’, because they are insufficiently distinct from *Homo sapiens*.¹⁰⁷ Consider the following statement by proponents of the multiregional school:

‘Neandertals have much larger browridges than living Europeans, and they are always continuously developed across the forehead. A significant number of recent and living Indigenous Aboriginal Australians have large, continuously developed browridges. Does this make them more primitive than Europeans? Does this make the Neandertals modern?’¹⁰⁸

If you believe that certain skull traits are indicative of a more ‘primitive’ status, then the above questions pose a real problem.

According to Stringer and Gamble,

‘The Neandertals were not apemen, nor missing links—they were as human as us, but they represented a different brand of humanity, one with a distinctive blend of primitive and advanced characteristics.’¹⁰⁹

This seems at best a confusing statement, as how can one say the Neandertals were ‘as human as us’, and then immediately follow this by a qualifier that ‘they represented

a different brand of humanity’? Either they were human or they were not. As aptly put by Lubenow, ‘The Neandertal problem is primarily the evolutionists’ problem. Simply put, evolutionists don’t know where the Neandertals came from or where they went.’¹¹⁰ To creationists, Neandertals were fully human. There is no basis for considering some skull features as more primitive than others because we are all equally human, regardless of the diversity of features that exists within the human *kind*, and because there never were any apemen.

Homo floresiensis

Media headlines in late October 2004, such as ‘Lost race of human “hobbits” unearthed on Indonesian island’,¹¹¹ must have astonished every ‘hominid’ watcher on the planet. For once, the incredible media ‘hoopla’ surrounding the announcement of yet another supposed new hominid species, *Homo floresiensis*, was not overrated, although the assignment of a new species name to these hobbits seems a bit premature, as, despite their small size, the remains may well be descendants of Adam.¹¹² The hobbits must have had substantial seafaring skills to reach Flores and sophisticated cognitive abilities, ‘as indicated by the technology of the stone artifacts associated with *H. floresiensis* at Liang Bua’.¹¹³ If the tools belonged to *floresiensis*, which seems very likely, then these people clearly possessed human intelligence.

The finding of fossils from hobbit-size people, who appear to have possessed human intelligence, with one specimen (LB1) evolutionarily dated to around 18,000 years ago and standing about 1 metre tall, with a cranial capacity of approximately 380 cm³,¹¹⁴ questions the notion of an arbitrary cerebral rubicon (at least at the 600–800 cm³ brain size level)¹¹⁵ that must be passed in order to have a human mental faculty. People with microcephalic brains (400–600 cm³),¹¹⁶ as well as dwarf humans (517 cm³),¹¹⁷ also have brain sizes measured below this arbitrary rubicon. The average brain size of chimpanzees is 383 cm³, orangutans, 404 cm³, and gorillas, 504 cm³.⁴² Hence, the 380 cm³ brain size of *floresiensis* from the Indonesian island of Flores is very small if it is human. However, when considering brain size, one should also take into account body size. This is done when calculating a value known as the encephalization quotient (EQ).¹¹⁸ If the body of *floresiensis* specimen LB1 is assumed lean and narrow, then the estimated EQ places LB1 easily within the *erectus* range.¹¹⁹

In terms of similarity, LB1 is described as: ‘In the overall shape of its skull and its teeth, the creature most closely resembles *Homo erectus*.’¹²⁰ Despite its small stature and cranial capacity, LB1 had few other things in common with the australopithecines. According to the authors of the *floresiensis* paper:

‘... it does not have the great postcanine tooth size, deep and prognathic facial skeleton, and masticatory adaptations common to members

of this genus. Instead, the facial and dental proportions, postcranial anatomy consistent with human-like obligate bipedalism, and a masticatory apparatus most similar in relative size and function to modern humans all support assignment to the genus *Homo*—as does the inferred phylogenetic history, which includes endemic dwarfing of *H. erectus*.¹²¹

Peter Brown, paleoanthropologist and first author of the *floresiensis* *Nature* paper, in regards to the hobbit's small cranium, commented that 'The internal structure of the brain—the neural pathways—must have been more human-like than ape-like to be able to make these types of tools.'¹²² An even more likely scenario is that the internal structure of *floresiensis*' brain was human, as was the brain architecture of many other fossil specimens with small craniums, in particular those assigned to *erectus*.

The team who unearthed the find suggests that *floresiensis* may be the descendants of *erectus* from the nearby island of Java, believed to have been there as long as 1.6 Ma.¹²³ They comment that the first hominid immigrants to Flores 'may have had a similar body size to *H. erectus* and early *Homo*, with subsequent dwarfing; or, an unknown small-bodied and small-brained hominin may have arrived on Flores from the Sunda Shelf'.¹¹⁹ An alternative view is that *floresiensis* is 'a miniature human being exhibiting part of the same range of post-Babel human variation as encompasses the larger so-called *Homo erectus*'.¹²⁴ Claims have been made by pathologist Maciej Henneberg of the University of Adelaide that the LB1 individual suffered from a pathological growth condition called secondary microcephaly, and that 'the skull of the Flores hominid is very similar to a 4,000-year-old microcephalic modern human skull found on the island of Crete'.¹²⁵ Also, Indonesian paleoanthropologist Teuku Jacob is reported to have said the LB1 skeletal remains were from a 'modern human, *Homo sapiens*, that lived about 1,300 to 1,800 years ago' who was a member of the 'Australomelanesid race, which had dwelled across almost all of the Indonesian islands',¹²⁴ and that the Flores people suffered 'from microcephaly which shrank their brains to the size of a chimpanzee's'.¹²⁶ However, the more remains of these tiny individuals that are found, the stronger the argument against LB1 being a diseased individual is, and there are reports of another lower jaw identical in shape and size to LB1's.⁵⁶

The controversy over the hobbit may well result in two rival camps feuding over the issue, a bit like the ongoing quarrel between the Out of Africa and multiregional schools of thought over the origin of modern humans. If so, don't expect any resolution soon. However, even if the specimens turn out to be pathological, the use of sophisticated tools, even by 'abnormal' people, indicates that they were quite intelligent, and illustrates that brain size, *per se*, is not as important as neural organization.

Conclusion

Homo habilis consists of fossil specimens that can either be classified as extinct australopithecine apes or as humans, with some of the latter displaying *Homo erectus* characteristics. Without the burden of having to fit fossils into an evolutionary scheme, there is no reason not to accept fossils such as those categorized as *erectus*, and Neandertals as belonging to the one human *kind*. Differences in skeletal anatomy may simply reflect a greater genetic diversity within the human *kind* in the past, and in some instances living under particularly harsh environmental conditions, or even dietary habits, may have influenced skeletal development. The stress of peculiar biomechanical forces, as well as pathology,¹²⁷ may also have influenced skull and postcranial morphology in some instances. The Bible also indicates that people lived longer in the past, with longevity declining post-Flood. As most of the fossils would have belonged to early post-Flood humans, it is possible that their natural lifespans may have been greater than those of people today. Hence, it is unclear what effect longevity, and possibly a different rate of skeletal maturation, would have had on skeletal features.

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Fossil evidence for alleged apemen—Part 2: non-Homo hominids

Peter Line

The aim of this overview is to critically analyze the fossil evidence for the alleged apemen that are not classified in the genus *Homo*. Each of these hominid candidate species will be examined in roughly 'evolutionary' chronological order, beginning with the earliest. The skeletal morphology of these alleged apemen indicates they were extinct apes that had nothing to do with human evolution.

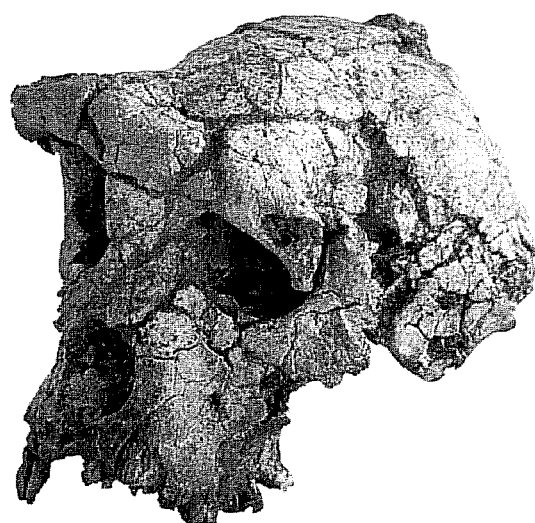
The supposed apemen belong to a category of fossils known as hominids, a group that includes living humans, their ancestors and any other ape-like creature believed to be more closely related to humans than to chimpanzees. Some evolutionists now refer to this group as hominins.¹ The term hominid is nonsensical from a creationist point of view, because the hominids were either human or apes, not anything in-between. The term is used here only to categorize these fossils, and does not imply a belief that such creatures really existed. According to evolutionists, the defining moment for determining a hominid is the hypothesized split between humans and chimpanzees. In the past the human and chimpanzee calibration point has been determined by a molecular clock to be 5 million years ago (Ma), using as calibration point the supposed split between Old World monkeys and apes 30 Ma, as determined by conventional radiometric dating of fossils.² The split is now thought, by evolutionists, to have occurred about 5–7 Ma. Radiometric dating³ and molecular clocks⁴ are based on unproven and problematic assumptions. When the evolutionary ages of fossils are given in this article, it is for the purpose of putting them in an evolutionary context, and it in no way implies that these age dates are valid.

The australopithecines refer to the members of the genus *Australopithecus*, and in earlier times this was the only hominid genus apart from *Homo*. However, in recent years many hominids have been assigned to new taxa outside *Australopithecus*, such as the genus *Ardipithecus*, *Sahelanthropus*, *Orrorin* and *Kenyanthropus*. From a creation point of view, it should be remembered that a species is not equivalent to a biblical *kind*.⁵

Sahelanthropus tchadensis

If publicity surrounding the announcement of a fossil find is anything to go by, then *Sahelanthropus tchadensis* is the frontrunner for the title of earliest hominid, as the hype was extraordinary even for apemen fossils, which have a reputation for making a lot of 'noise' on arrival. The cranium of *Sahelanthropus* (TM 266-01-060-1, nicknamed Toumai), found in Chad, Central Africa, was featured on the cover of the 11 July 2002 issue of *Nature*, with the title 'The earliest known hominid'. The single cranium and other fossils (fragmentary lower jaws) were dated by the researchers, using associated fauna, to be between 6 and 7 Ma, with the cranium estimated to have a cranial capacity somewhere between 320 to 380 cm³.⁶ The odd thing about the Toumai cranium is that it looks chimpanzee-like from the back, but from the front it is said by one expert to pass as an advanced australopithecine.⁷ According to Bernard Wood, a hominid of Toumai's supposed age 'should not have the face of a hominid less than one-third of its geological age'.⁷ Hence, if evolutionists accept *Sahelanthropus* as the earliest stem hominid, then this casts legitimate doubt on the human ancestry status of all other hominids with more 'primitive' faces,⁷ and, as such, would invalidate most of the geologically younger australopithecines.

Almost before the print had dried on the hyped headlines surrounding Toumai's arrival, other evolutionists, including Brigitte Senut of the Natural History museum in Paris, expressed doubt about Toumai's hominid status. In an interview, she stated her view as tending 'towards thinking this is the skull of a female gorilla'.⁸ This hardly corroborates Harvard paleontologist Daniel Lieberman's earlier



Sahelanthropus tchadensis, best known by the cranium (TM 266-01-060-1) nicknamed Toumai, was announced to the world as the earliest-known hominid in July, 2002, amid extraordinary publicity. However, the relegation of *Sahelanthropus* to an ape, by some experts, did not receive the same media attention.

grandiose claim about Toumai being ‘the most important fossil discovery in living memory’.⁹ A team led by Wolpoff argued that Toumai’s impressive supraorbitals (large brow ridges), which are greater than in any australopithecine or extant ape, were more likely to be a mechanical response to strain,¹⁰ and not an indicator of facial similarity to the genus *Homo*. Examination of scars left on the back of the skull from neck muscle attachments led them to conclude that Toumai was a quadruped (i.e. walked on four legs, not two).¹¹ After their examination of Toumai, they stated their belief ‘that *Sahelanthropus* was an ape’.¹² Another alleged hominid feature of Toumai is its small canines compared to extant apes.¹³ Although *Sahelanthropus* differs from extant gorillas in some features, there are also many similarities, and according to Matthew Murdock there is a strong possibility that *Sahelanthropus* and extant gorillas are related in the sense that they are both members of the same biblical *kind*.¹⁴ If this is correct, then the small canines may just reflect greater canine size variation existing in this ape *kind* in the past, with the genetic information for small canines subsequently lost.

Recently, claims have been made that one of the molars in the mandible was glued in the wrong place, and that an incisor collected at the site was not featured in the original *Nature* paper.¹⁵ The authors argued that the fossils attributed to *Sahelanthropus* ‘are the subject of debate as to whether they represent a hominid or an ape. It is therefore necessary to provide full and accurate details of the fossil collection.’¹⁶ As so often happens in paleoanthropology when the establishment is challenged, the pair making the claims suffered a backlash.¹⁷ Also predictable was that the relegation of *Sahelanthropus* to an ape followed the familiar pattern of not getting anywhere near the same media attention that greeted its initial ascension to apeman.

Orrorin tugenensis

Early in 2001 *Orrorin tugenensis*, claimed to have lived about 6 Ma, was announced as a candidate for the earliest hominid (the fossil bones were found in Kenya’s Tugen Hills), by a team of researchers led by Brigitte Senut and Martin Pickford.¹⁸ The fossils consisted of 13 pieces, including broken femurs, several teeth, and bits of lower jaw.¹⁹ Hence, it is not possible to know what the head of this creature looked like. The only reason *Orrorin* has claims to early hominid status, as well as claims of bipedality, is that it was found in the right evolutionary time period. Bipedalism is considered by evolutionists to be important evidence of hominid status. *Orrorin* supposedly walked on two legs because of an alleged human-like femur (thigh bone), based on its long femoral neck and a groove on the back of this neck which is present in humans, but absent in chimpanzees.²⁰ However, this groove, where the *obturator externus* muscle presses against the bone, is also found in non-bipeds,²¹ and according to one expert, scans through *Orrorin*’s femoral neck show a chimp-like distribution of

cortical bone.²⁰ Another argument is that the head of the femur in *Orrorin* is proportionally larger than Lucy’s, and evolving a large-headed femur would help dissipate the forces caused by bipedalism.²² The team controversially suggested that *Orrorin* had independently evolved bipedalism, separately from Lucy and other species of *Australopithecus*, whom they relegated to an extinct side-branch of the hominid family.²²

The controversy of *Orrorin* resumed again in September 2004 with the publication of the results of computerized tomography (CT) scans of the femur, claiming a non-ape, later hominid, distribution of cortical bone in the neck-shaft junction of *Orrorin*’s femur, indicating bipedal locomotion.²³ As reported by Ann Gibbons, when speaking about these latest finds:

‘Senut proposed that *Orrorin*’s gait was more humanlike than that of the 2- to 4-million-year-old australopithecines. If so, australopithecines would be bumped off the direct line to humans—a dramatic revision of our prehistory.’²⁴

Paleoanthropologist Tim White disagreed with this ‘gait’ assessment and attacked the latest published findings by saying that ‘the resolution of the CT scans was so poor that it was impossible to be certain of the pattern of bone thickness’.²⁴ White also ‘called Senut’s displacement of australopithecines “une position créationniste”, because it suggests that *Orrorin*’s femur was quite modern 6 million years ago, rather than evolving by stages’.²⁴ It seems that even evolutionists that stray outside the orthodox evolution hominid story risk a backlash.

According to David Begun of the University of Toronto, the evidence for bipedalism in *Orrorin* is ambiguous.²¹ Soon after the initial publication of the fossils, Begun commented that the fossil fragments representing *Orrorin* could not reveal whether it was ‘on the line to humans, on the line to chimps, a common ancestor to both, or just an extinct side branch’.¹⁹

Ardipithecus kadabba

A few months after *Orrorin tugenensis* was announced, another early hominid candidate, from Middle Awash, Ethiopia, called *Ardipithecus ramidus kadabba*, dated to between 5.2 and 5.8 Ma, was described in the journal *Nature*.²⁵ The name of this specimen was, in 2004, elevated from subspecies status to a separate species, *Ardipithecus kadabba*, based on the recovery of additional fossil teeth.²⁶ In *kadabba* (as in *Orrorin*) the fossil finds consisted of some postcranial bones, teeth, and jaw fragments, and so it is not known what the head of these creatures looked like.

The *kadabba* specimen is interpreted as a biped based on the characteristics of a single toe bone (a proximal foot phalanx), in particular the dorsal orientation of the proximal joint surface.²⁷ The argument is that the toe bone’s joint surface is tilted upwards in a human-like manner, whereas in chimpanzees it tilts downwards, and so it is supposedly

evidence that *kadabba* 'toed off' in a human-like manner when walking.²⁸ However, as pointed out by Begun,

'the same joint configuration occurs in the definitely non-bipedal late Miocene hominid *Sivapithecus*, and the length and curvature of this bone closely resembles those of a chimpanzee or bonobo'.²⁹

Amazingly, the toe bone is dated several hundred thousand years younger than the rest of the fossils, and was found in a locality 16 km away from the rest, making even famous hominid hunter Donald Johanson dubious about categorizing the toe bone with the rest of the fossils.³⁰

From the few (eleven) fossil scraps, belonging to at least five different individuals, from five different locations,²⁵ it seems amazing that they can all be designated as belonging to the same subspecies, and later, on the basis of finding some additional teeth,²⁶ that the fossils can be assigned to a new species. According to Balter and Gibbons, 'The *Orrorin* and *Ardipithecus* teams assert that each other's fossils could represent an ancestor of chimps or other apes, rather than one of our early human ancestors or cousins'.³¹ Perhaps both teams are partially right, as there is little doubt that both hominids were mere apes.

Ardipithecus ramidus

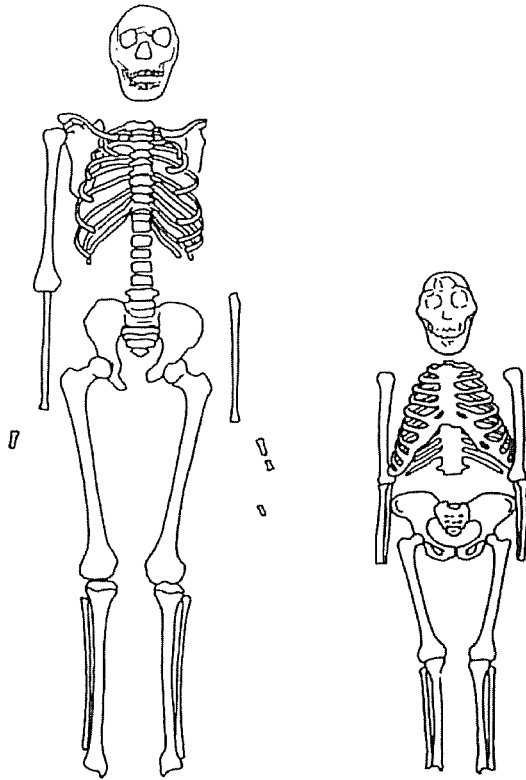
In 1994 a team led by Tim White announced the finding of *Australopithecus ramidus* from Aramis, Ethiopia, which, at the time, being dated at 4.4 Ma, was the earliest 'hominid' find of any significance.³² About eight months later, in a corrigendum, the authors reclassified the fossils into an entirely new genus, *Ardipithecus*, with the new species name being *Ardipithecus ramidus*.³³ The original article was accompanied by a cover photo, in the 22 September 1994 issue of *Nature*, of a small jaw fragment from *Ardipithecus ramidus*, containing an embedded tooth, with the title 'Earliest hominids'. Hence, one would have expected a significant find, but instead the fossils, comprising postcranial, dental and cranial scraps, in the authors own words, 'shows a host of characters usually associated with modern apes'.³⁴ The authors argue for hominid status mainly based on a more incisiform canine morphology and a more anterior position of the foramen magnum, as they believe 'Acquisition of these states at Aramis may correlate with bipedality although this remains to be demonstrated'.³⁵ Even in the evolution community, not everyone is convinced that *ramidus* is a hominid. According to Peter Andrews, of London's Natural History Museum, the thin enamel on the teeth of *ramidus* 'is more of what you'd expect from a fossil chimp', and the features of an upper arm bone 'suggests knuckle-walking, chimp-style'.³⁶ Recently, more fossil scraps from Afar, Ethiopia (jaws, teeth, toe and finger bones), were assigned to at least nine *ramidus* individuals, and claims of bipedality were made based on the dorsal orientation of the proximal joint surface of a proximal foot phalanx, a feature also seen in *kadabba*.³⁷ See the *kadabba* section above for a refutation of this bipedality claim.

Australopithecus anamensis

In 1995, dental, cranial and postcranial specimens from two separate localities in Kenya, dated from about 3.8 to 4.2 Ma, were announced as belonging to a new hominid species, *Australopithecus anamensis*.³⁸ Most of the fossil scraps undoubtedly came from an ape, such as the chimp-like jaws, but controversy has surrounded the alleged more human-like nature of the tibia and humerus.³⁹ The *anamensis* humerus lacks a deep, oval hollow, used as a locking mechanism between the humerus and ulna, the latter being present in chimpanzees, but not in humans, and the *anamensis* tibia is wide, as in humans, because of extra spongy tissue, which acts as shock absorbers during bipedal locomotion.⁴⁰ At the time of publication, paleontologist Peter Andrews raised the suggestion that the tibia and humerus, coming from different sections (upper level) of the Kanapoi locality strata than the 'primitive' jaws and teeth (lower level), might possibly 'be related to humans and the other to apes'.⁴¹ There were some mandible fragments (KNM-KP 29287) found in upper-level strata, but these were from a different (higher) level than the tibia (KNM-KP 29285) and humerus (KNM-KP 271).⁴² At the time there was also the problem of several hundred thousand years in evolutionary time between the upper and lower levels, but in a later paper, dates were obtained that narrowed the time gap.⁴³ In this later article additional finds of fossil scraps from *anamensis* were reported, but no additional evidence was provided associating them with the tibia and humerus. Also, the 2000 analysis of a fossil radius (KNM-ER 20419) from the other *anamensis* location, Allia Bay, indicated 'specialized wrist morphology associated with knuckle-walking'.⁴⁴ In a paper co-authored by Meave Leakey, *anamensis* is said to be very like *afarensis*, postcranially, with the humerus, tibia and radius 'almost exactly matched in size and morphology to the *A. afarensis* collections from Hadar'.⁴⁵ Hence, if the postcranial remains do belong to *anamensis*, then at most you have an ape-like creature with a similar locomotion pattern to the ape-like *afarensis*. As more in-depth analysis has been performed on *afarensis*, which has more postcranial fossils attributed to it, the reader is referred to that section.

Australopithecus afarensis

The discovery of the famous Lucy skeleton in Ethiopia in 1974⁴⁶ and the controversy over the naming of *Australopithecus afarensis* in 1978⁴⁷ are well known and will not be retold here. The estimated cranial capacity of *afarensis*, whose evolutionary time range was from about 3.0 to 3.9 Ma, is between 375 and 540 cm³, with a mean of about 470 cm³,⁴⁸ although the mean brain size is elsewhere given as 438 cm³.⁴⁹ Above the neck, the skull (including jaws) of *afarensis* has been described as ape-like,⁵⁰ with evolutionary experts distinguishing its cranium from that of chimpanzees, mainly due to smaller canine and larger postcanine teeth in *afarensis*, 'and the influence the smaller canines has on



The *Homo erectus* skeleton of KNM-WT 15000 (left) is compared to the australopithecine *afarensis* skeleton of Lucy (right). There is a huge morphological gap between the essentially modern human postcranial skeleton of *erectus* and that of the australopithecine postcranial skeleton, as represented by Lucy. For example, the conical-shaped rib cage of Lucy suggests she was thick-waisted with a pot-bellied abdomen, like chimpanzees. Also, there is wide flaring of the ilia of Lucy's pelvis, compared to the narrower ilia of humans. For further discussion, see Mehlert.¹¹³ (Image from Walker and Shipman.¹¹⁴)

the face of *A. afarensis*, including the reduced snout and the presence of a canine fossa'.⁵¹ Details of the first skull of *afarensis* (AL 444-2) were published in 1994,⁵² and at the time it was the largest australopithecine skull known,⁵³ with an estimated cranial capacity later determined to be 540 cm³.⁵⁰ Previous to this the reconstruction of the *afarensis* skull was a composite, based on fossil fragments from several individuals,⁵⁴ and as a result there were accusations that Kimbel and White, who made the composite skull, 'had force-fit the face of a slender *Homo*-like species onto the brain case of a robust one'.⁵⁵

Postcranially, *afarensis* possessed ape-like features such as a conical-shaped rib cage, and, along with other australopithecines, were heavily built for their stature and 'almost certainly were not adapted to a striding gait and running, as humans are'.⁵⁶ Humans have barrel-shaped rib cages, and by comparison to apes, are lightly built for their stature. Analysis of the socket of the shoulder blade (scapula) of *afarensis* showed that it was directed far more cranially (skywards) compared to humans,⁵⁷ whose socket is perpendicular to the ground, and that, like apes, this upward orientation of the *afarensis* socket would have been

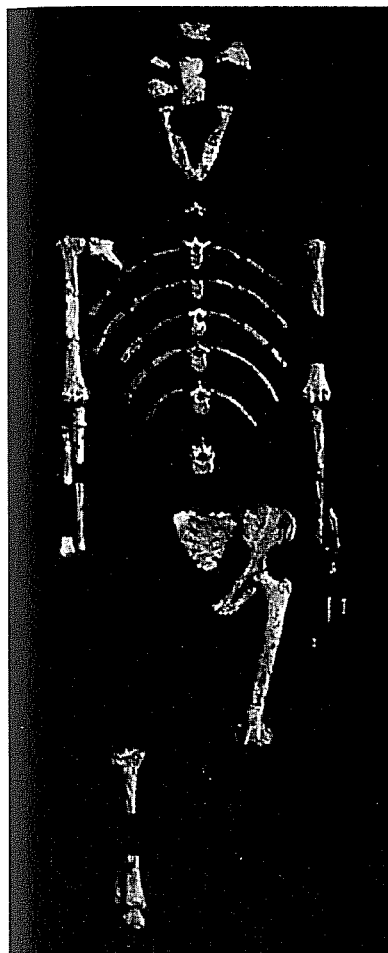
'valuable if the arm were held overhead much of the time, as it is when climbing and hanging in trees'.⁵⁸ As for limb proportions, the estimated humerofemoral index (ratio of humerus to femur length) in *afarensis* is less than that of extant apes, although still significantly greater than that of humans.⁵⁹ Humans have relatively short arms and very long legs, and according to Tattersall and Schwartz, it is a 'fact that the legs of *afarensis* were quite short'.⁶⁰ The estimated brachial index (ratio of radius to humerus length) in *afarensis* is greater than that of humans and gorillas, but less than that of other extant apes, but this estimated index is very unreliable because of the difficulty in making a reliable length estimate of the radius of Lucy (AL 288-1), and a generous length estimate of the radius would bring the brachial index within the chimpanzee range.⁶¹ However, Tattersall and Schwartz state that

'even if the relative proportions of the arms are more humanlike than apelike (the lower arm is much longer compared with the upper arm in chimpanzees and especially the full-time arborealists—orangutans and gibbons)—the arms of *afarensis* were still quite long'.⁶⁰

The bones of the fingers in *afarensis*, particularly the proximal phalanges, are curved, similar to those of chimpanzees, and 'indicate adaptation for suspensory and climbing activities which require powerful grasping abilities'.⁶² The toes of *afarensis* are also curved,⁶³ as in apes, and suggest an ability to climb trees. According to Stern and Susman, the foot and ankle remains of *afarensis* 'reveal to us an animal that engaged in climbing as well as bipedality'.⁶⁴ They go on to state that 'There is no evidence that any extant primate has long, curved, heavily muscled hands and feet for any purpose other than to meet the demands of full or part-time arboreal life'.⁶⁴

The analysis by Stern and Susman, in 1983, of *afarensis* hand fossils indicated many features in common with chimpanzees, but they pointed out that examination of the metacarpals yielded no evidence that *afarensis* was a knuckle-walker.⁶⁵ Evidence for *afarensis* being a knuckle-walker would surface later, however. The wrist morphology in extant knuckle-walking African apes (chimpanzees and gorillas) has a specialized locking mechanism that limits 'wrist extension during the support phase of knuckle-walking'.⁴⁴ In 2000 Richmond and Strait reported that the distal radial morphology (including the scaphoid notch) in *anamensis* and *afarensis* was similar to that of the knuckle-walking African apes, whereas the radius attributed to *robustus*, and in particular *africanus*, was more human-like.⁶⁶ Amazingly, the authors suggested that the knuckle-walking features in *anamensis* and *afarensis* were non-functional retentions from an earlier ancestor.⁶⁷ However, non-functional retentions (evolutionary baggage) are not something that is expected to persist for long, according to evolutionist Jeremy Cherfas:

'Everything about her skeleton, from fingertips to toes, suggests that Lucy and her sisters retain several traits that would be very suitable for climbing



Lucy is the most famous *Australopithecus afarensis* specimen, with about 40% of the postcranial skeleton recovered.

in trees. Some of those same tree-climbing adaptations can still be detected, albeit much reduced, in much later hominids such as the 2-million-year-old specimens of *Homo habilis* from the Olduvai gorge. It could be argued that Lucy's arboreal adaptations are just a hangover from her tree-dwelling past, but animals do not often retain traits that they do not use, and to find those same features in specimens 2 million years later makes it most unlikely that they are remnants.⁶⁸

Another point of interest from the Richmond and Strait study was that the

wrist morphology in *affricanus* was more 'modern' than that of *afarensis*. However, other studies have indicated that the foot, lower leg and limb proportions in *affricanus* are more ape-like than in *afarensis*, although the skull of *afarensis* is more chimpanzee-like than *affricanus*.⁶⁹ One might well wonder what the supposed evolutionary relationship between *affricanus* and *afarensis* is in this complicated picture, as *afarensis* has been proposed as the ancestor of *affricanus*. According to Collard and Aiello:

'It is no longer a case of the skull pointing to one set of phylogenetic relationships, and the postcranial skeleton—everything but the skull—to another. Rather, different parts of the postcranium may not support the same phylogenetic hypothesis.'⁶⁹

In regards to Lucy, according to archaeology professor Clive Gamble:

'The anatomy shows a fully bipedal gait but with some differences from modern humans. Indeed, these are so distinctive that in his exhaustive study of the limbs Charles Oxnard concluded that

the method of locomotion was neither ape-like nor human. Nor was it a midway stage but truly unique.'⁷⁰

The central argument for *afarensis* being a hominid is that the creature had an erect posture and was capable of bipedal locomotion. The argument that *afarensis* was bipedal is based on skeletal reconstructions of the pelvis and lower limb bones. As up to 40% of Lucy's postcranial skeleton was recovered, a lot of the morphological and biomechanical analyses are based on these bones, although not exclusively so. One problem with reconstructions of Lucy's skeleton (dated to about 3.2 Ma) is the subjective nature of the work, as predetermined belief about the posture of *afarensis* may bias the reconstruction of the skeleton. How else can the following statement by Maurice Abitbol, who studied Lucy's pelvis, make sense?

'Prevailing views of Lucy's posture are almost impossible to reconcile. When one looks at the reconstruction proposed by Lovejoy (1998) and by Weaver *et al.* (1985), one gets the impression that her fleshed reconstruction would be the body of a perfectly modern human biped (Figure 1a). But when one looks at the preliminary reconstruction recently shown at the Smithsonian, one gets the impression of a chimpanzee awkwardly attempting to stand on its hindlimbs and about to fall on its frontlimbs (Lewin, 1988). In the latter, the implication is a "primitive" form of bipedality in the Hadar hominids. To resolve such differences, more anatomical (fossil) evidence is needed. The available data at present are open to widely different interpretations.'⁷¹

Amazingly, Lucy's posture can be interpreted to be anything from modern human to chimpanzee-like. Hence, creationists have every right to be extremely sceptical of claims that Lucy and other australopithecines were at a stage of evolution between human and apes, when the main evidence for that claim is based on such speculative interpretation of data. From his study, Abitbol concluded that 'Lucy's erect posture is unlike that seen in modern humans and is still a mystery'.⁷²

Another problem with studies that investigate the locomotion capability of fossils belonging to creatures such as *afarensis* is that discussions about muscular functions 'assume *a priori* that the muscles were in a close to human pattern'.⁷³ In a biomechanical analysis of Lucy's pelvis and lower limb bones, in particular the reconstruction of the *gluteal musculature*, Christine Berge reported that 'an ape-like gluteal organization would offer better ability than a human-like one'.⁷³ From the study, Berge concluded

'that the bipedalism of *Australopithecus* must have differed from that of *Homo*. Not only did *Australopithecus* have less ability to maintain hip and knee extension during the walk, but also probably moved the pelvis and lower limb differently. It seems that the australopithecine walk differed

significantly from that of humans, involving a sort of waddling gait, with large rotatory movements of the pelvis and shoulders around the vertebral column (Berge, 1991a, b). Such a walk, likely required a greater energetic cost than does human bipedalism.⁷⁴

From their detailed analysis of the postcranial skeleton, Stern and Susman 'discovered a substantial body of evidence indicating that arboreal activities were so important to *A. afarensis* that morphologic adaptations permitting adept movement in trees were maintained'.⁷⁵ Concerning *afarensis*, they also concluded 'that the nature of terrestrial bipedality, when it was practiced, was different from modern humans'.⁷⁵ Also, CT scans by a group led by anatomist Fred Spoor of the University of Liverpool of the bony labyrinth (fluid-filled semicircular canals) of the inner ear, which is part of the vestibular apparatus responsible for balance,⁷⁶ showed that the semicircular canal dimensions in crania attributed to other australopithecines (*africanus* and *robustus*) were similar to that of extant great apes.⁷⁷ Although scans of *afarensis* were not performed, it is likely that the labyrinths of *afarensis* would resemble the same chimp/ape pattern as these other australopithecines.⁷⁸ Hence, the evidence indicates that it is very unlikely that *afarensis* was a habitual bipedal walker. It is also not clear whether the limited bipedalism exhibited by some australopithecines, such as *afarensis*, was postural and related to feeding, as opposed to locomotion.⁷⁹ It should be remembered that extant bonobos (pygmy chimpanzees) have been observed to walk bipedally about 10% of the time, so limited non-human bipedalism occurs even in extant apes.⁷⁹

So what exactly do we have in *afarensis*? The answer is a creature with the brain the size of an ape, a skull that was ape-like with a body similar in shape and size to an ape, and a creature that was specialized for climbing in trees and knuckle walking, similar to apes. In other words, you have an ape. However, if *afarensis* also had some limited ability for non-human bipedal locomotion, which was perhaps more efficient than that of extant bonobos, is this evidence that the creature was an apeman, or does it just reflect the diversity of the ape/australopithecine body structure that God created?

That the answer lies with the latter is indicated in the analysis of the skeletal remains of an ape from Italy called *Oreopithecus bambolii*, dated from 7 to 9 Ma, whom nobody appears to want to label a hominid, as the fossil remains are in the wrong location and outside the hominid time 'window', yet *bambolii* had an anatomy supporting limited bipedal locomotion.⁸⁰ According to the authors of the study, parts of the pelvis of *bambolii* resembled that of *afarensis*, and its femur showed 'a pronounced diaphyseal angle combined with condyles of subequal size, similar to *Australopithecus* and *Homo* and functionally correlated with bipedal activities'.⁸¹ According to Henry Gee, 'this creature is thought to have become bipedal independently and was only distantly related to hominids'.⁸² Apes evol-

ing a form of bipedal locomotion once is difficult enough to believe or imagine; that it must have independently happened multiple times, in order to 'rescue' evolutionary theory, reveals evolution to be a collection of just-so stories that can be accommodated to almost any scenario, no matter how absurd or unlikely. That a limited non-human form of bipedal locomotion existed in apes unrelated to, and earlier than, any hypothetical hominid, indicates that possession of bipedal traits are not indicative of hominid status.

Kenyanthropus platyops

In March 2001 yet another 'hominid' appeared on the cover of *Nature*, with the headlines reading 'The human family expands'. Inside was an article describing a new creature, from Lake Turkana, Kenya, called *Kenyanthropus platyops*.⁸³ Being dated at 3.5 Ma has brought *platyops* into direct competition with *afarensis* as the trunk hominid that supposedly gave rise to the genus *Homo*.⁸⁴ The main excitement was over a badly distorted cranium. Its cranial capacity was estimated to be of ape proportions, but largely because of its flat face, unusual for a supposed hominid at that stage of evolution, the specimen was assigned to a new genus *Kenyanthropus*. However, there are strong indications that the flat face was due to severe expanding matrix distortion, an artifact of the fossilization process,⁸⁵ and so *platyops* is undoubtedly just another ape.

Australopithecus bahrelghazali

In 1995 the mandible from this creature, found in Chad, was described as being most similar to the contemporary species *afarensis*.⁸⁶ The specimen from Chad, date estimated at between 3 and 3.5 Ma, was, in 1996, assigned to the new species *Australopithecus bahrelghazali*. It was judged different from *afarensis* on certain morphological features of the mandible, premolar roots and premolar enamel thickness. However, such a meager find hardly warrants the creation of a new species. There is no reason to view *bahrelghazali* as anything but an ape, probably of the same kind as *afarensis*.

Australopithecus africanus

The mean brain size of seven specimens of *Australopithecus africanus* is 451 cm³, with a range from 425 cm³ to 515 cm³.⁸⁷ Evolutionists believe that *africanus* lived in South Africa from about 2.5 to 3 Ma, although it may have persisted until 2 Ma.⁸⁸ Cranially, the main difference in comparison to *afarensis* is in the face, with the face of *africanus* less prognathic and broader.⁸⁹ Also, in comparison to *afarensis*, the *africanus* lower jaw has a more robust body, the postcanine teeth are enlarged in size, and the anterior teeth are reduced.⁸⁹

Australopithecus afarensis is considered by many as being ancestral to *africanus*, but comparisons of the limb

proportions of the two species indicate less ape-like forelimb to hindlimb joint sizes and limb lengths in the supposedly older and craniodentally more 'primitive' *afarensis*.⁹⁰ According to the authors of these studies, 'This implies that limb proportions changed back and forth in the hominid lineage or our present view of hominid relationships is too simplified'.⁹¹ Rather, the confusion of hominid relationships exists because there never was an evolutionary relationship between hominids to begin with. According to Klein and Edgar, *africanus* possessed a very ape-like upper body, with long, powerful arms suitable for tree climbing, but the lower body was 'shaped for habitual bipedal locomotion on the ground'.⁹² However, as mentioned above, CT scans of the bony labyrinth of the inner ear showed that the semicircular canal dimensions in crania attributed to *africanus* were similar to those of extant great apes.⁷⁷ Hence, if *africanus* did walk bipedally in some manner, it is unlikely to have been habitually.

An earlier analysis of the postcranial anatomy of *afarensis* and *africanus* led McHenry to the conclusion

'that (1) the postcranial skeleton of early *Australopithecus* was uniquely different from all living apes and people, (2) the postcranial skeleton of early *A. africanus* is very similar to *A. afarensis* despite real differences in their skulls, teeth, distribution, and age, and (3) there is a distinct grade of locomotor adaptation in *Australopithecus* which is unlike any living form'.⁹³

Hence, if the two species shared 'a unique configuration which implies that locomotor and postural adaptations were very similar and unlike any living form',⁹⁴ then the locomotor behaviour of *africanus* was similar to *afarensis*. As indicated earlier, *afarensis* was a knuckle-walking ape built

for an arboreal lifestyle, although it may have had a limited ability to walk bipedally in a non-human-like manner, as did apes unrelated to any supposed hominid evolution, such as *Oreopithecus bambolii*. As with all other australopithecine species, *africanus* possessed brains the size of apes, had ape-like skulls, and was similar in body shape and size to apes. Hence, the most plausible explanation is that *africanus* was a species of extinct ape, and even among evolutionists there have been suggestions that *africanus* and *afarensis* 'should be considered subspecies of a single species'.⁹⁵

Australopithecus garhi

In 1999 the remains of *Australopithecus garhi*, a supposed 2.5-million-year-old hominid from the Hata beds of Ethiopia's Middle Awash, was said to be distinguished from *afarensis* 'by its absolutely larger postcanine dentition and an upper third premolar morphology with reduced mesio-buccal enamel line projection and less occlusal asymmetry'.⁹⁶ However, when viewing the very incomplete cranial remains of the creature, with a cranial capacity estimated at 450 cm³, it is difficult not to wonder whether differences in a few dental features have been overemphasized, as this specimen surely could have been assigned to the species *afarensis*. Perhaps the later evolutionary date was a factor. Regardless of its affinity to *afarensis*, the ape-like nature of its skull establishes *garhi* as nothing more than an ape.

More interesting were the postcranial fossils (BOU-VP-12/1) recovered at the locality, which the researchers did not assign to *garhi*, featuring a human-like humerofemoral index.⁹⁷ However, the Bouri skeleton (BOU-VP-12/1) also had an estimated brachial index larger than all extant apes, except orangutans (*Pongo pygmaeus*).⁹⁸ This combination of a long, ape-like forearm and human-like humerofemoral limb proportions makes for a confusing ancestor-descendant evolutionary relationship, as it 'would suggest a reversal in brachial proportions in the Bouri skeleton (more ape-like) from the *A. afarensis* condition, followed by a second reversal in *H. ergaster* (more human-like)'.⁹⁹

The robust australopithecines

The robust australopithecines are conventionally made up of the species *Australopithecus robustus* (1.5 to 1.8 Ma) from South Africa, and the two East African species *Australopithecus boisei* (1.3 to 2.3 Ma) and *Australopithecus aethiopicus* (2.3 to 2.7 Ma), with the combined evolutionary age range for the three species from 1.3 to 2.7 Ma.¹⁰⁰ Some paleoanthropologists assign them to a separate genus, *Paranthropus*. None of the robust australopithecine species are regarded by evolutionists as ancestors of true humans, but rather as side branches that met a dead end,¹⁰¹ 'because their teeth and skulls were so specialized and because they coexisted with more plausible ancestors after 2.5 million years ago'.¹⁰² It is because of 'their huge chewing teeth and rugged skulls' that they have been called robust



Photo by David Green

The *Australopithecus africanus* cranium STS 5 (nicknamed 'Mrs Ples') is one of the most complete australopithecine crania ever found. It was discovered in 1947 by Robert Broom and John Robinson at Sterkfontein, South Africa. It has a cranial capacity of about 485 cm³.

australopithecines, although they had small brains and bodies.¹⁰³ From the skulls of these creatures, it is obvious that there was nothing human-like about them.

Australopithecus aethiopicus

The famous 'Black Skull' (KNM-WT 17000), with a cranial capacity of about 410 cm³, is one of the three or four fossil specimens making up the species *aethiopicus*,¹⁰⁴ which is considered by some evolutionists to be a plausible link between *afarensis* and the other two robust species, *boisei* and *robustus*.¹⁰⁵ However, the Black Skull 'is an extreme *A. robustus/boisei* type with a massive sagittal crest, and the two teeth found are four or five times as large as human molars',¹⁰⁶ and so even though *aethiopicus* is supposedly an older species than *robustus/boisei*, its hyper-robustness disqualifies it as a transitional form. The morphology of the Black Skull has many similarities to that of a small male gorilla,¹⁰⁷ and so it is possible that gorillas and *aethiopicus* belong to the same biblical kind. There are currently no postcranial fossils assigned to *aethiopicus*, the other two (possibly three) specimens attributed to *aethiopicus* being mandibles.¹⁰⁸

Australopithecus boisei

The mean brain size of *Australopithecus boisei*, based on six specimens, is about 452 cm³, with a range from 390 cm³ to 500 cm³,¹⁰⁹ although other estimates of *boisei* give a mean of 521 cm³.⁴⁹ Cranially, *boisei* is described as 'the only hominin that combines a massive, wide, flat, face with a modest-sized neurocranium'.¹¹⁰ There are no postcranial remains that can definitely be attributed to *boisei*, but from Koobi Fora a partial skeleton and individual postcranial bones have been inconclusively linked with the species.¹¹⁰ According to Wood and Richmond, 'The partial skeleton is characterised by limb proportions that resemble *A. afarensis* (Grausz *et al.* 1988), and are less apelike than those of *A. africanus*'.¹¹⁰ Hence, if the partial skeleton (KNM-ER 1500) did belong to *boisei*, then it may have had similar locomotor behaviour to that of *afarensis*, and 'like *A. afarensis*, the relatively long forelimb suggests that the locomotor behaviour of *P. boisei* included an arboreal component'.¹¹¹

Australopithecus robustus

The brain size of *Australopithecus robustus*, which currently can only be estimated for one specimen (SK 1585), was 530 cm³, but a more recent estimate has lowered that to 476 cm³.¹⁰⁹ Cranially, *robustus* was similar to that of *boisei*, but its face was not as large and wide.¹¹⁰ Hence, if *robustus* had a 'robust' skull, then the skull of *boisei* was hyper-robust. In comparison to *africanus*, the chewing teeth and face of *robustus* were larger, although its canine and incisor teeth were smaller,¹¹² and according to Klein and Edgar, both species

'possessed very ape-like upper bodies with



Photo by Warwick Armstrong

As can be seen from this replica skull of *Australopithecus boisei*, there was nothing human about the heads of the robust australopithecines. In a similar replica at the San Diego Museum of Man, a lower jaw has been included, which is based on a fossil found 50 miles away.

long, powerful arms that would have made them agile tree climbers. They differed from apes primarily in their lower bodies, which were shaped for habitual bipedal locomotion on the ground, and in their teeth'.⁹²

According to Wood and Richmond, the morphology of the pelvis and hip believed to be associated with *robustus* resembles that of *afarensis* and *africanus* (the 'gracile' australopithecines), and suggests that 'the gait of *P. robustus* probably resembled that of the 'gracile' australopiths'.¹¹² As indicated earlier, the gait of *afarensis* was not human-like. Also, as mentioned previously, CT scans of the bony labyrinth of the inner ear showed that the semicircular canal dimensions in crania attributed to *robustus* were similar to that of extant great apes.⁷⁷

Conclusion

The morphological features of the hominid fossils assigned to taxa outside the genus *Homo* indicate they were mere extinct apes. A species is not equivalent to a biblical kind, and several of the non-*Homo* hominids may just represent variation within one or more ape kinds, just as the fossil species included in *Homo*, excluding the invalid taxon *Homo habilis*, are believed to represent variation within the one human kind. It may well be that extant apes are surviving remnants of these hominid ape kinds, which have lost much of their genetic diversity. In general, where fossil material is available, these hominid creatures had brains the size of apes, skulls that were ape-like, and bodies similar in shape and stature to apes. The morphology of creatures such as *Australopithecus afarensis* indicates that they were special-

ized for climbing in trees, as well as knuckle walking, as are apes. Much has been made of skeletal features, indicating some of the australopithecines, including *afarensis*, may also have had limited ability for non-human bipedal locomotion. However, similar limited bipedal ability also existed in apes not considered hominids, such as *Oreopithecus bambolii*, dated to earlier than the supposed human and chimpanzee split. Hence, how can a trait be used as an argument for the uniqueness of all hominids, and their evolutionary relationship, when the trait is not unique to these supposed hominids? It is like saying whales must have evolved from creatures like hippopotamuses because they can both swim (or do they believe that, too?). I suppose this is why evolutionists like the word parallel so much, as in parallel evolution. Call it what you like, but is it science?

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